

Writing and printing

Ancient peoples first invented writing to record information and thoughts through signs, symbols, or letters. Records could be kept, and people could communicate without meeting. The later invention of printing meant that multiple copies of a document with words and pictures could be reproduced much faster and more accurately.

The first writing

- **What?** Cuneiform
- **Who?** Sumerians
- **Where and when?** Mesopotamia, 3100 BCE



Early cuneiform

The ancient Sumerians were among the first people to live in organized towns and soon needed a system to keep track of the goods they traded, the animals they kept, and the taxes they paid. They invented a style of writing that used wedge-shaped marks made on clay tablets with a stylus. Today, this is known as cuneiform. Within 400 years, signs representing words were in use across Mesopotamia.

Papyrus

- **What?** Writing surface
- **Who?** Ancient Egyptians
- **Where and when?** Egypt, 3000 BCE

The ancient Egyptians developed a new writing surface. This was made from the inner stem of the papyrus plant. The plant was cut into strips, which were laid together to form sheets, moistened, and dried. They were written on with a reed pen and ink.



Ancient Egyptians used a pictorial script called hieroglyphs.



Script on turtle shell

Oracle bone script

- **What?** Earliest known Chinese writing
- **Who?** Ancient Chinese
- **Where and when?** China, 1200 BCE

In ancient China, people tried to foretell the future by carving questions onto animal bones (usually ox) or turtle shell. These bones were heated until they cracked, and the patterns of the cracks were read as answers to the questions. The characters used on oracle bones represented words, not speech sounds, and are the first known example of Chinese writing.